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Anastasia?

BY PHILIP WHITWELL WILSON

Is the mysterious young woman lately sheltered by Mrs. Leeds in America the strangely rescued daughter of the late Czar, or a most ingenious impostor?

ON THE eastern slopes of the Ural Mountains, facing Siberia, there is a city, founded by Peter the Great, that has changed its name. The Bolsheviks call it Sverdlovsk. But in memory of the Empress Catherine I it used to be known as Ekaterinburg.

In this city, there is a street called the Vosnesensky Prospect. Here may be seen a mansion, now a museum, that once belonged to a person of property, called Ipatieff. During the spring of 1918, Ipatieff was expelled from his home by the local Soviet and the mansion was known henceforth as "the Place of Special Appointment".

In July, 1918, this house accommodated the Czar Nicholas, the Czarina Alexandra, the Czarevich Alexis, the Grand Duchesses Olga, Tatiana, Maria and Anastasia, their nurse Anna, the family physician, Dr. Botkin, and a number of servants, Trupp, Sednev and Chumadurov, with the cook Haritonov, his assistant, the sailor Nagorny who attended the Czarevich, and two others. The members of the entourage were invited by the Soviet authorities to leave the service of the royal family. Anna, Dr.

Botkin and about three others remained faithful to the end.

At ten o'clock of July 16, 1918, certain Commissars informed the Czar and his household that they must move immediately out of the suite of five rooms which they were occupying. The house stands on land that falls away to the rear and the back door opens out of the cellar or basement upon a lower street. Outside this door there stood a motor vehicle, with its engine running.

The entire company proceeded downstairs into the cellar, expecting to enter this motor vehicle. Suddenly they were lined against a wall. A brief death warrant was read. They were then shot. Their bodies were removed to a forest and burned. The reigning branch of the Romanoff Dynasty was obliterated, and the place where the house stands is today called the Square of National Vengeance.

ON FEBRUARY 17, 1920, nineteen months later, a girl attempted to commit suicide by jumping into the River Spree at Berlin. She was rescued and taken to the Elizabeth Hospital. She refused to give her

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address or the reason for her action. On the ground that she was suffering from hysteria, she was removed to the insane asylum at Dalldorf, where she was registered as "Miss Unknown".

In 1922, an inmate by name Frau Peutert was released from the institution. Among the Russian colony she spread the astonishing story that "Miss Unknown", with whom she had lived in the same room for two years, was none other than the Grand Duchess Anastasia. Frau Peutert was very persistent, and at length a descendent of the Baltic nobility, Baron von Kleist, visited the girl, took her into his home and informed the Danish Ambassador, Zahle. Among exiled Russians, including Romanoffs, no little curiosity was aroused.

THE girl fell ill of tuberculosis and was returned to the Elizabeth Hospital. On her discharge, she found that Baron Kleist was no longer willing to be her host, and she vanished. But at the Baron's suggestion, Police Commissioner Gruenberg traced her to the home of Frau Peutert. In his turn, he was so impressed that he took the girl into his own flat, treating her as a member of his family.

Next door to the Police Commissioner, Gruenberg, there lived a masseuse, called Gesella, whose reverence for royalty was deeply stirred by the spectacle of "Miss Unknown". With the assistance of a priest, by name Sonnenschein, Frau Gesella had the girl removed to the fashionable Mommsen Sanitarium in Berlin, where she received gifts and visitors and became a subject of speculation and controversy throughout Europe.

The girl was then befriended by the family of Leuchtenberg, of the House

of Beauharnais, which has long been Russian. She stayed at the Château de Seeon, in Bavaria, the seat of Duke George Nicolaievich.

As Princess Xenia of Greece, Mrs. W. B. Leeds is a cousin of the Romanoffs and, therefore, of the Grand Duchess Anastasia. Immense was the interest, then, when it was learned that Mr. W. B. Leeds had invited the unknown girl to cross the Atlantic and had given to the immigration authorities a guarantee that her maintenance would be provided. On February 7, 1928, she arrived at New York on the *Berengaria*.

THE question that confronts us is, then, simple. Is this girl or is she not the Grand Duchess Anastasia? It is a question that suggests a situation teeming with romantic uncertainties. Whoever she may be, there is no doubt that Miss Unknown is now involved in a maze of worldwide conspiracies, assertions and denials, with every motive invoked, whether of loyalty, jealousy or self interest.

It goes without saying that the claim is ridiculed by the Bolsheviks. A Soviet official is quoted as saying: "We consider the matter to be a New Year's joke." With Russia mystical and steadily becoming more conservative, the Russian Republic has no desire to be faced by a daughter of the Czar, raised from the dead.

On this subject, if on no other, the majority of royalties in Europe agree with the Bolsheviks. A commission of inquiry, appointed by them, reported to the Dowager Empress Marie that the girl "has nothing in common with the Grand Duchess Anastasia" and must be regarded as an impostor. To a negative verdict, the Grand Duchesses

Xenia and Olga, sisters of the late Czar and aunts of Anastasia, have appended their signatures. So has the late Czarina's sister, the Marchioness of Milford Haven, with other near relatives of the Grand Duchess Anastasia.

There is evidence that great pressure has been brought to bear on Duke George of Leuchtenberg and the Leeds family by the Romanoffs with a view to depriving the girl of support. In both directions it is said that confidence has been "shaken".

On behalf of Mr. Leeds, a statement has been made that the girl merely wanted to "regain her health and to lead the normal life of any normal young woman". He and his wife, the Princess Xenia, were "not trying to get any fortune for her" or "to prove that she is the Grand Duchess".

On the other hand, the claims of this girl are being examined "not as a case but as a cause" by a well known New York lawyer, Mr. E. H. Fallows, whose standing is beyond question, and the person of the claimant is guarded with a vigilance which recalls the precautions that used to be taken to protect the Czars themselves.

HERE, then, is a mystery. It is a mystery on which the public has a right to form an opinion. It is a mystery to be examined strictly on its merits. The royal condemnation of Miss Unknown's claims is a fact not to be ignored. But it is absurd to regard this condemnation as decisive. There may be reasons, financial and dynastic, why the Romanoffs and their relatives desire at all costs to dispose of Anastasia's apparent resurrection from the dead. These exiled royalties are not disinterested. Indeed, they

are rivals and partisans and their views must be weighed accordingly.

It has frequently been stated that the Czar had funds invested in Europe. In British banks, these deposits have been estimated by rumor to reach eighty million dollars, and one suggestion is that King George should arbitrate on their distribution. Others hint that the funds are much exaggerated or entirely fictitious. Insurances on the Czar's life are said, moreover, to have been realized. When, indeed, the Grand Duchess Cyril, sister of Queen Marie of Rumania, visited the United States in 1924 as alleged Czarina, it was hinted that she was looking into funds said to be held by banks in this country. Hence, the Grand Duke "Alexander" (presumably, Nicholas), uncle of the Czar, who lives in Paris and is the head of the Romanoffs, does not hesitate to hint that Miss Unknown may be after the money.

ONE reason, it is said, why the Romanoffs hesitate to claim the Czar's fortune, is their reluctance to admit that, at the moment when nobles were exhorted to sacrifice everything to the country, Nicholas was hoarding a nest egg outside Russia.

The late Czarina was a Princess of Hesse. Her brother is the present Grand Duke. To whatever property the Czarina left in Germany, he has a claim. He is bitterly opposed to the girl.

In his case, there is alleged to be an additional reason for hostility. The statement is that the girl mentioned him at once as a visitor to the Czarina in the year 1916. This would have meant that, despite a state of war, the Grand Duke, as a German, and the

Czarina, as a Russian, had held secret conferences, a singularly interesting disclosure for all concerned.

On the Austrian side there were such negotiations. Prince Sixtus of Parma did visit his sister, the Empress Zita, and almost induced Austria-Hungary to conclude a separate peace. To the Grand Duke of Hesse, the disclosure of his alleged intrigue by Miss Unknown was nothing less than "a catastrophe".

It is he who has led the fight against Miss Unknown. How bitter has been the struggle is proved by an incident at his former capital, Darmstadt, where Count von Hardenberg discovered and was attacked by thieves, trying to open the safe in his house, where papers affecting this case were said to be kept.

IN ALLOWING for prejudice, we must bear in mind the succession to the Russian throne. Assuming that, as a woman, a Grand Duchess could not succeed, this would not prevent her being the mother of a son who would be Czar. It is easy to understand why, for instance, the Grand Duke Cyril, with his little Court at Gotha thus threatened, did not wait to see the girl before denouncing her as an impostor. Yet his brother, the Grand Duke Andrew, was convinced that Miss Unknown is the genuine Anastasia and said it with emphasis. It is now reported from Nice that the Grand Duke Cyril has at last allowed himself to be convinced in favor of the girl. It is a case where, as things stand, no one's word is to be accepted as gospel, except after a careful analysis of the probabilities.

Whenever an important person dies from a violent cause and under myste-

rious circumstances, there is a tendency to assume that the victim, like Lord Kitchener who was drowned, still lives. In 1483, the little princes, Edward V and his brother, Richard of York, disappeared in the Tower of London. Perkin Warbeck, a native of Tournay, impersonated Richard, was recognized in France, and actually made civil war in England. Yet he was executed as an impostor, not unjustly. For in the reign of Charles II, the bones of the Princes were discovered in the Tower, near a staircase, and now rest in Westminster Abbey.

The little Dauphin, son of King Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette, who perished on the guillotine, was also, as Louis XVII, long sought and believed to be alive. Yet he was never found and the plain truth must be accepted that, at an early age, he perished. Numerous instances of this kind could be given, and they imply that, in all such cases, a claimant must be refused, as it were, the benefit of the doubt. The claim must be proved.

A more recent case is that of "John Orth", the Austrian Archduke, whose disappearance at sea gave rise to innumerable rumors.

ALREADY, the Romanoffs have provided several pretenders. A young man in Poland, afflicted with hæmophilia, claims to be the Czarevich Alexis. In Odessa, a boy and girl, posing as Alexis and the Grand Duchess Tatiana, were arrested. Simultaneously, a second Tatiana appeared and received gifts from the peasants, including butter and eggs, which were sold at a profit. Is Miss Unknown yet another instance of this kind?

It is here that the attitude of the late Empress Marie requires some ex-

planation. She was, of course, the mother of the Czar and the grandmother, therefore, of Anastasia. For reasons of her own, this venerable lady, nearing her eighties, had refused to accept as certain the statement of her son's death. It may have been pride. It may have been affection. It may have been superstition. But it was also statecraft. Until the titular head of the House of Romanoff admitted that the throne was vacant, all claimants to the throne were in the position of pretenders.

Yet the aged Empress, though affecting to believe that her son, the Czar, was still alive, displayed the utmost skepticism over the alleged Grand Duchess in Berlin. Of course, the survival of such a Grand Duchess would be an added proof that the Czar did not survive.

AN ELUCIDATION of the mystery now surrounding Miss Unknown must be presented in two chapters. First, what happened to this girl before she threw herself into the River Spree? Secondly, what precisely was the impression which she created afterward?

We may clear the ground by dealing here with the cycle of legends in which the heroine was Anastasia's elder sister, Tatiana. In November, 1917, it was asserted that the Grand Duchess Tatiana, disguised by a fictitious marriage with a son of the Court Chamberlain, whose name is given as Count Fredericks, escaped by way of Vladivostok to San Francisco. Indeed, a Russian dancer, Mlle. Ekaterina Galanta, stated in New York that she was offered five hundred dollars a week to proceed to San Francisco and impersonate Tatiana. A variant of this story was that Tatiana cut her hair, dressed

as a man and sought to reach England by way of Archangel.

BETWEEN the case of Tatiana and the case of Anastasia, there is this important distinction. Tatiana is always supposed to have eluded the Bolsheviks at Tobolsk, or, at any rate, before the Czar was taken on his last journey to Ekaterinberg. Miss Unknown, on the other hand, asserts that she went, not only to the Ipatieff mansion but even into the fatal cellar. She herself disposes of any idea that she escaped from the Bolsheviks before the executions took place. With the mansion surrounded by a stockade of wood, such an escape would have been difficult.

At the shootings, which of course occupied only a minute or two of time, Miss Unknown, who, in any event, cannot have been in a position to observe things very closely, says that, according to her recollection, she cried out in pain and fainted. She awoke in a peasant's cart, the bottom of which was strewn with straw. In the cart, there was a soldier of the Red Guard, another young man and an old woman.

The Red Guard gave his name as Tchaikowsky. He said that he had been a member of the firing squad, and when the bodies were taken to the forest to be burned, he noticed that Anastasia was alive. He covered her with burlap and the other soldiers did not notice the little heap on the ground.

For three months, the girl and her rescuer crossed Russia. Her wounds were bathed with water from running streams. The fugitives arrived in Bucharest and went to live in a little house of a gardener, an uncle of the

Red Guard. The girl there succumbed to brain fever and her head was packed in snow. But no doctor was called in.

In Bucharest, she married the Red Guard and bore him a son. They lived by selling emeralds which the girl, following the known practice of the ill-fated Romanoffs, had sewn into her clothes. During a disturbance in Bucharest, the Bolsheviks shot the Red Guard in the street. A brother of the Red Guard brought her to Berlin, where in February, 1920, she was penniless and threw herself into the River Spree.

WHEN a story of this kind is told, the first question that arises is whether there is corroboration. Let us see. In the cart, there were an old woman and a young man. Neither has been produced. The Red Guard is dead. His brother, who brought Miss Unknown to Berlin, is also still to be traced. There is no certain knowledge of the baby. There was no doctor. Elaborate inquiries in Europe are said to be proceeding, but whatever be their result the fact will remain that eight years will have elapsed since Miss Unknown attempted suicide without any authentic information on these important points.

It is said that Mrs. Leeds has sent detectives to Rumania to trace the certificate of marriage, if there is one, and the boy, said to have been born. It will be seen whether results are achieved.

With regard to the boy, we have one hint. There is a peasant family, it is said, named Colentin, living near Bucharest. With this family, a baby was left and money was furnished until the mother should return. One day, an elegantly dressed woman, with two

men, drove up to the cottage and forcibly took the boy with them. The interesting report does not tell us where the boy was taken, nor are we informed whether his well-dressed captors were friends or foes of Miss Unknown.

Assuming that this boy is the son of Miss Unknown, that she was legally married to Tchaikowsky, and that she is Anastasia, we can understand, perhaps, why there has had to be a certain reticence in handling a situation so delicate. For, in those events, this boy would be — or if now dead, would have been — the Czar of All the Russias, and that Czar would have in his veins the blood of a Red Guard who, actually, was responsible in a measure for the massacre of his mother's family. Also, we can discern a very human reason why Miss Unknown, bred in the exclusive atmosphere of a court, has been so sensitive as to conceal her identity and even to attempt suicide.

STILL, there are points to be explained. We are told by Mr. Gleb E. Botkin, son of Dr. Botkin, the late Czar's physician, that after her husband's death in Bucharest, Miss Unknown went to Berlin in order to get into touch with her royal kith and kin. But in Bucharest itself there was royalty on the throne of Rumania, eager for a restoration of the Czardom in Russia. Queen Marie is Anastasia's first cousin, once removed. She is a sister of the Grand Duchess Cyril. Yet there is no suggestion, apparently, that Miss Unknown made her presence known to the Court.

The girl's narrative, unsupported as it is by testimony other than her own, must be tested then by cross examina-

tion. Let us take first the actual scene in the cellar. The Red Guard said that he belonged to the firing party. Miss Bella Cohen, who spent weeks in Berlin, seeing Miss Unknown and investigating her affair, assumes that she was injured by the bayonet, of which wounds the scars remained. But according to the Soviet report, issued wholly without reference to this case, no Red Guards entered the cellar. The executions were carried out by four Commissars armed with pistols.

It is true that the number of Red Guards was increased from eight to seventeen. But so great was the dread of a rescue that these soldiers were kept at a distance and in ignorance of the killings. We read:

Even the guards did not know, and for two days more, they changed guards regularly.

The shootings were not announced in the press till July 23, or some days after the White troops had arrived.

Being hysterical in that cellar and lapsing into unconsciousness, Anastasia could not have known for certain whether Red Guards did or did not take part in the scene. But the story of her husband is called in question.

ON THE executions, we have another witness, Sergius Michaelovich Trufanoff, otherwise Iliador, the "Mad Monk" and former chaplain of the Czar. He states that in March, 1918, he returned to Russia, and was arrested by the Bolsheviks. "Stalin and I," he says, "had been theological students together," owing to which old friendship he was allowed to proceed through the fighting between Reds and Whites to Ekaterinburg, where he was admitted as a visitor to the Ipatieff mansion.

Iliador's testimony is, at least, specific. He says that the seventeen Red Guards were stationed a hundred yards from the mansion, but that they heard the shots and the screams. Twelve bodies were removed later on two trucks. A day or two later, all the Red Guards, save one survivor, were barricaded in a hut as barracks, which hut was fired, so burning them to death. The one guard who survived is Iliador's "intimate friend", and he could be "got here with care through Latvia".

By a coincidence, this one Red Guard who survived, carried Anastasia's body from the truck to the place of burning. Also, as the body was stripped, he possessed himself of a medallion, worn by Anastasia and given her by Rasputin. It consists of a token of Jehovah, in mother of pearl, and is suspended in a chain of snake scales.

ON THE authority of this Red Guard, somewhere in Russia, Iliador asserts that no soldiers entered the cellar during the executions, that Commissars carried out the sentence with their pistols, and that Anastasia was killed by three bullets—one in the head, another above the heart and a third shattering the bones of the jaw.

Iliador's statement is, like Miss Unknown's, unsupported. He has not produced his "intimate friend". The story that the Red Guards were burned alive, is sensational. The reason would be a dread of the advancing White Army and a wish to annihilate all evidence of the grim deed at the Ipatieff mansion.

The executions took place on July 16. Three days later, the White Army, consisting of eighty officers and two

machine guns, arrived and incidentally cut off the head of a statue of Karl Marx which adorns the Square of National Vengeance. The White officers eagerly sought for survivors of the Romanoff family. According to one account, they tore up the floor of the cellar and washed the blood off the cement, distributing the sacred soap-suds to eager ecclesiastics. But they discovered no survivor of the imperial household, whether Anastasia, Tatiana, Alexis or anyone else.

THIS, however, does not disprove Miss Unknown's story. She has always stated that her escape was entirely independent of the White Army, and in an opposite direction. It is arguable that the Red Guard could have restored the girl, then and there, to her friends and that, in going to Rumania, he took the long road instead of the short cut to a haven of royalism. But, regarded as a regicide, he had no reason to suppose that the White Army, with emotions stirred by the massacre at Ekaterinburg, would have welcomed him as a hero. Also, the fact that the Red Army was in precipitous retreat is, so far as it goes, an explanation of the Red Guard's own journey westwards.

There appear to have been two occasions when the forest, where the bodies were burned, was searched by the royalists. The Kolchak army looked over the place but, it is hinted by the Bolsheviks, did not actually find the ashes. But at a later date, 1924, General Janin obtained possession of the ashes at Ekaterinburg and brought them to Paris, where they are held in some place, absolutely hidden, a prospective challenge to the rival relics of Lenin in Moscow.

However this may be, the Romanoff report, condemning Miss Unknown, states that in the forest parts of corsets were discovered which indicated that six women had perished. These would be the Czarina, the nurse Anna, and all the four Grand Duchesses. If this evidence be accepted, it is proof of Anastasia's death. But it is subject to the strong prejudice against her developed by the Romanoffs, and it would be interesting to see the actual parts of the corsets, on which the conclusion is based. Amid such débris, the difference between five and six is a fine one.

Summing up on Miss Unknown's story, we may say, then, that it is improbable and not corroborated, but that it is not impossible, still less disproved. We must hold our judgment in suspense.

AT THIS point, the next move lies obviously with the Romanoffs. They deny that Miss Unknown is Anastasia. Then, who is she? Have they been able to prove that she is any one else? Admittedly, they have tried their hardest to produce an alibi. The question is whether they have succeeded.

Mr. Gleb E. Botkin states outright that the story, here following, has been exploded in the German press as "a fraud". If it be true that the opponents of Miss Unknown have had to resort to such tactics in order to discredit her, the point must be given heavily in her favor. But let us see.

In the summer of 1922, it is said, she disappeared for three days from the house of Baron von Kleist where, as we have seen, she was a guest. After three days, she returned wearing different clothes. Seeing a discussion in the newspapers, a certain Dame Wing-

ender, living in Berlin, called on the editor of the *Nachtausgabe* with the clothes, which Baroness von Kleist identified. Dame Wingender also recognized the girl as one who had lodged in her house.

It has been suggested that this evidence disproves Miss Unknown's claim. As it stands, it does not affect it. It is agreed that Miss Unknown concealed her identity. The fact that a landlady did not know who she was is neither here nor there.

THE police were asked, therefore, to search their *dossiers* and seek for somebody corresponding to Miss Unknown. It is admitted, apparently, that they were paid for their trouble and, so encouraged, they produced the very person required. Apparently, they searched their files for a man called Tchaikovsky, the name of the alleged Red Guard. They found such a man, who had recently died a sudden death. It seems that he had been executed as a murderer. His wife was stated to be a Polish woman, called Franziska Schanzkowski, born on December 16, 1896, at Borowellas, Pomerania, and married on January 18, 1919. At her marriage, she changed her religion to the Roman Catholic faith and also her maiden name to Anna Romansky, under which name she was registered on the license.

Over this, there has been a violent controversy. The only correspondence established between the Polish girl and Miss Unknown appears to be handwriting. Such a clue, especially when offered by the police in return for money, is notoriously unreliable. After all, why should Franziska Schanzkowski change her name to Anna Romansky in order to marry a man

called Tchaikowsky? It may have happened. But if it did happen, what has it to do with Miss Unknown?

The handling of the affair by the press hardly adds to our confidence. The *Nachtausgabe* began by demonstrating that Miss Unknown was Anastasia. Suddenly, it published articles proving the exact opposite. The *Tagliche Rundschau* attributed this change of attitude to a payment of about five thousand dollars, alleged to have been made to the *Nachtausgabe* by the Grand Duke of Hesse, who wished, as we have seen, to discredit Miss Unknown. Libel actions have been started and are being prosecuted, and of two such lawsuits, so Mr. Botkin says, one has been won by an adherent of Miss Unknown, while the other was postponed, month by month, at the instance of the judge, who advocated a settlement out of court to avoid scandal.

Under these circumstances, we take it that the opponents of Miss Unknown do not rely on the story of the Polish peasant girl. But if this be the fact, it means that, despite an expenditure of money in the press and among the police, they have failed wholly to prove that Miss Unknown is any other person than the Grand Duchess Anastasia. Miss Unknown's story of what happened before she attempted suicide is the only story not yet discredited.

WE HAVE NOW to examine what, if any, proof of definite identification has been produced on her behalf.

Certain friends of Miss Unknown never met the Grand Duchess Anastasia in the former days. Their testimony is thus relevant only to her demeanor. It is incontestable that this

girl, staying for months at a time in the most exclusive and aristocratic homes, has behaved as a highly bred lady of position. The Danish Ambassador, Wahle, the Baron von Kleist, and the Police Commissioner, Gruenberg, were all impressed by her personality. In the summer of 1925, Dr. Joseph F. Kapp, of New York, called on Miss Unknown at Gruenberg's flat, and reported; "If she is an impostor, she certainly is of noble birth and well used to moving in high society."

TAKE next her language. The evidence is that, in the sanitarium, she understood Russian but spoke only a broken German. Apparently her English, which was often used at the Russian Court, was faulty. She said, "If I heard it spoken around me, it would come back to me in a month."

The position today, after Miss Unknown has recuperated, is stated to be that she has a perfect command of Russian, of the classical variety used in society; that she speaks English fluently, only hesitating at times for a word; and that her German is what she would have picked up during her exile. She speaks no Polish. Any idea that this woman is a peasant appears to be directly contrary to the reported facts.

Dr. Kapp, above quoted, when seeing Miss Unknown at Gruenberg's, noticed "two distinct deepening of the parietal bones of the cranium", one of them "affecting the understanding of words". He added that "the deepening in the skull were distinctly artefacts and might have been caused by some accident or an act of violence". Moreover, they might ex-

plain, he thought, the failure of Miss Unknown to recall her languages.

In the nature of things, these tests could not prove that the girl is Anastasia. But they do demonstrate that her facility of speech is precisely what would have been Anastasia's, had she received and gradually recovered from the treatment from which Anastasia suffered. Indeed, there is direct medical evidence from Professor Rudnef, the girl's physician, that in her delirium she spoke Russian.

WE COME next to the identifications. Countess Zenida Tolstoy was the wife of an officer in the Russian dragoons. To the last, she corresponded with the Imperial family. She has unmasked two pretenders, but says of Miss Unknown that she resembles Tatiana, not Anastasia. There was six years difference between the sisters, Tatiana was the elder, and it would not have been strange if Anastasia had grown to resemble her.

The Crown Princess Cecilie of Prussia had seen Anastasia only many years before, and then only as a plump little girl. She did not commit herself absolutely, but declared, "I am convinced the girl is not an impostor."

The Grand Duchess Olga, as sister of the late Czar, is Anastasia's aunt. What she now says is that Miss Unknown bears no resemblance to Anastasia, whether in looks, voice or personality; that she knows of the Russian Court only "just what is common knowledge"; and that "of all my questions relating to former days, friends or any intimacies, she could not answer one".

Also, we have Dr. Kostritsky, described as the family dental surgeon, who, it is said, examined plaster

casts of Miss Unknown's upper and lower jaws, finding "complete dissimilarity" with Anastasia's. "Comparative analysis of photographs," he reports, "led to the same conclusion".

A Somersetshire woman, Miss H. Eager, who was six years in the Romanoff nursery, said that Miss Unknown was certainly not Anastasia. One had black eyes, the other had blue-grey eyes. One had black hair, the other had light brown hair. One talked Polish and Lithuanian, the other talked English, French and Russian. One blessed herself in the Roman fashion, the other belonged to the Greek Church.

Also, we have the statement that Anastasia refused to see a former Court Lady, Baroness Buhaven; while Pierre Gilliard, who was tutor to the Czarevich for fourteen years, now declares that Miss Unknown offers "an almost flawless impersonation".

IN so far as all this evidence is negative, it is not original. It is rebuttal. Take the dentist's testimony. It is agreed that Miss Unknown's jaw has been badly reset and that she has lost teeth. Yet a cast of this jaw, compared with photographs, is held to be proof of dissimilarity. It is the kind of evidence which expert witnesses in the courts offer every day, first on one side, then on the other.

Again, what about Pierre Gilliard? In how many instances has an impersonation, declared in any event to have been "almost flawless", stood the test of years of varied and intensive scrutiny?

With regard to Miss Eager's testimony as quoted, it is directly contrary to Miss Bella Cohen's description of Miss Unknown, which has been

that her eyes are deep blue, not black, while her hair, so far from being black, is red brown, which, it may be added, was the exact color of the Czarina's hair at Miss Unknown's age.

LET us turn, then, from the later evidence to the earlier and more authentic impressions of Miss Unknown, on the part of competent witnesses.

Take first the testimony of Pierre Gilliard, the tutor of the Czarevich. He is now a witness for the Grand Duke of Hesse against Miss Unknown. But what was he at the outset? His wife is, we gather, Sascha, who was nurse to Anastasia from her fourth month of babyhood to the Revolution — obviously, a witness of crucial importance.

What follows is based upon the important article contributed by Miss Bella Cohen to *The New York Times* of March 28, 1926. It is an article written after weeks of investigation into the case on the spot, that is, in Berlin. Miss Cohen had access, moreover, to the careful reports made by Wahle, the Danish Ambassador, a trained diplomat who acted under official responsibility.

It was decided to subject Miss Unknown to the severest possible test. Sascha, the nurse, was dressed in fashionable clothes. The Grand Duchess Olga was plainly and even poorly attired. Without warning, they appeared at the girl's bedside. Neither woman spoke. This was what happened:

The girl in the bed smiled. "Oh, my dear Aunt!" she cried in broken German. The strange woman who had stood behind the Grand Duchess stepped forward. The girl seized the hand of the stranger. "Zhura!" she

cried; "Zhura!" Tears poured down her cheeks and she kissed the hand of the strange woman.

"Zhura" had been a special pet name applied to Sascha by Anastasia alone.

The Grand Duchess reported:

My head says Anastasia cannot be alive . . . that no one of them could have survived. But my religion tells me to follow my heart. And my heart says she is Anastasia.

To Miss Unknown, the Grand Duchess Olga wrote: "Remember you are no longer alone." The girl was "my little one". Also we have endearments — "I think of you always," "I embrace you," all signed "Olga".

From this testimony, it is obvious, surely, that Olga's sole difficulty was in imagining how Miss Unknown could have escaped — that, over Miss Unknown herself, she had none of the uncertainties which she now asserts.

COMING to evidence based on the girl's memory, we must bear in mind two principles. First, we all are apt to forget, and, in cases where a severe shock has been suffered, it is only after a period of rest that the memory is restored. If, then, Miss Unknown failed to recognize a green stone pendant, shaped like an egg, which in happier days she had worn and then given to the nurse, Sascha, this is not to be set down against her.

Secondly, in estimating the importance of what she did remember, we have to admit that she may have picked up a detail, here and there, from her visitors. On the other hand, few if any of these visitors at that date were persons who had knowledge of the Russian Court on its inside, and the admission even by her opponents that Miss Unknown is wholly sincere

in her pretensions, means that consciously she has been no party to collusion or conspiracy.

WHAT, then, has she remembered? She told Olga and Sascha of her two parrots; of the staircase that led from the quarters of the Grand Duchesses to the rooms of their mother, the Czarina; of the custom whereby on Monday morning the daughters used to visit their mother while she was having her hair dressed; of an invalid lady-in-waiting, little known outside the palace, called Balyanova; of a woman, called Belgard, who used to solicit subscriptions for an orphan asylum; of necklaces, known to Olga, which the Grand Duchesses had received on their birthdays; of an occasion on the yacht, *Standart*, when Anastasia walked repeatedly before a sentry to make him salute and even tickled him, being spanked for her naughtiness by her father, the Czar; and of "Schwibzik," a pet name in the family for Olga.

With regard to "Schwibzik", it is alleged that Miss Unknown may have heard it from a lady who learned it from an officer who was sent in 1918 by Olga to Siberia to search for the imperial family. But even this would indicate that "Schwibzik" was so secret a name as to be available as a password.

Miss Unknown recognized Pierre Gilliard, and said, "You have cut your beard off." After all reservations, it must be allowed that, tested by memory, the points tell heavily in her favor.

Finally, we come to the most critical test of all. Are there or are there not characteristics of Miss Unknown's

body which correspond precisely to the known characteristics of the body of the Grand Duchess Anastasia? At the test interview, Miss Unknown at once agreed to an examination by Sascha, Anastasia's personal nurse during the whole of her girlhood. Sascha's report, to which the Grand Duchess Olga is a witness, was in these terms:

This is the body of Anastasia. I know her body as well as I know my own. Anastasia had a brown mole on her back — her birthmark. That mark is there. Anastasia had flat feet. This girl's feet are flat. They are the same shape as Anastasia's. In addition, Anastasia had a protruding bone on her left foot. That protrusion is still there. Her ears are the same size and shape as Anastasia's. Anastasia's middle finger was slightly crushed in her childhood when a servant caught it in an automobile door. The middle finger is still slightly out of shape. Her hair is darker than Anastasia's, but it still has the same wave.

Every woman knows that, with the passage of years, a certain kind of hair does lose its lightness of color.

IN BERLIN there was a doctor, Professor Rudnef. He had been a physician in Moscow and, during the Czardom, had been consulted over Anastasia's foot. He had advised against an operation. Professor Rudnef examined Miss Unknown's feet, including the unusual bone, and pronounced them to be the same as Anastasia's. An identification by the strictest of all tests thus yields the most positive results. A birthmark, a bruised finger and a slightly deformed foot, certified by a domestic nurse, who had tended the girl for

sixteen years, and confirmed in the case of the foot by a medical man, would seem to offer a proof as unerring almost as finger prints themselves.

YET the difficulties in this case must be admitted. Of those difficulties, we have a witness, all the more powerful because today he is an advocate on behalf of Miss Unknown. One of the most heroic victims at Ekaterinburg was Dr. Botkin, the Czar's physician. On the arrival of the White Army in that city, his son, Mr. Gleb E. Botkin, hurried to the place and searched for his father, but fruitlessly.

Mr. Botkin lives in New York, and when he heard of Anastasia's alleged appearance in Berlin, his comment was the same as Olga's—it was impossible. Yet on meeting Miss Unknown, he recognized her at once. In the old days, as he remembered, he had amused Anastasia with humorous drawings of animals. They exchanged such recollections.

We have here, therefore, a great improbability, counteracted, as it were, by an apparently overwhelming body of evidence. No one will deny to the Romanoff family and their imperial relatives every right to examine such a case with the most rigid exactitude. But if, in the eye of Omniscience, it be the fact that this bruised and wounded woman is really kith and kin to the imperial exiles, if no other explanation of her existence can be discovered without financial expenditure on the police and the press, there can scarcely fail to be created an unfortunate impression of what used to be admired as chivalry.